

Lentil-scallion fritters with feta cheese

These are very simple fritters, yet they have a fresh, lively taste. Make into 1- or 2-ounce [30- to 60-g] patties and serve as appetizers, or make larger patties and serve as a main course. For maximum flavor, don't skip the final step of spritzing each fritter with fresh lemon juice.

The Spicy Yogurt Sauce (page 111) is a **phenomenal** topping as well as an outrageous stand-alone dip. I highly recommend serving it alongside this dish. You will, however, have to make it ahead of time. Alternatively, you may want to try topping the fritters with Horseradish-Mustard Dip (page 25).

½ cup lentils [100g]

2 large shallots, minced

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

1 bunch of scallions, coarsely chopped

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 tablespoon coarse ground mustard

2 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

4 ounces feta cheese, crumbled (about 1 cup) [125g]

¼ to ⅓ cup dried bread crumbs [20 to 35g]

Several drops of hot sauce, or more to taste

Salt and freshly ground pepper

About ½ cup canola or safflower oil, for frying [125ml]

Lemon wedges

Spicy Yogurt Sauce (recipe on page 111)

1. In a saucepan of salted boiling water, **cook** the lentils over medium heat until soft, 25 to 30 minutes. Drain well, transfer to a large bowl, and let cool.
2. Meanwhile, in a medium skillet, **cook** the shallots in 1 tablespoon of the olive oil over medium-low heat until softened and just beginning to color, 2 to 3 minutes. Add the scallions and garlic and cook for another 2 minutes. Remove from the heat.

3. **Stir** the mustard, lemon juice, feta cheese, $\frac{1}{4}$ cup [60ml] of the shallot-scallion mixture, and the remaining olive oil into the lentils. Mash with a large fork until thoroughly blended. Add the bread crumbs and hot sauce. Mix well. Season with salt and pepper to taste. Add more bread crumbs, if necessary, to get the right consistency: a well-formed patty that holds together—not too dry, not too wet. Form into 16 small patties, about 2 inches [5cm] in diameter.
4. In a large skillet, **heat** 3 to 4 tablespoons of the canola oil over medium-high heat. Add as many patties as will fit in a single layer without crowding and fry until browned and crisp on both sides, 2 to 3 minutes. Fry the remaining fritters in batches, if necessary, adding more oil as needed to prevent sticking. Drain the fritters on paper towels.
5. **Serve** hot, with lemon wedges for spritzing. Pass the yogurt sauce on the side.

SERVES 4 (AS AN APPETIZER)

